Inquisitive semantics beyond questions

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Two types of informative updates: imposition and proposal

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- The discourse flow is not homogeneous.
- Some information is primary, it constitutes the main point of the utterance.
- Other information is in some sense secondary, it comments upon the content of the main point of the utterance, situates it in the context, or enriches the common ground so that the primary information can be uttered.

(1) a. Lupin, a werewolf, is teaching the Defense Against the Dark Arts this year.

b. Lupin, who is teaching the Defense Against the Dark Arts this year, is a werewolf.

c. Lupin is a werewolf and he is teaching the DADA this year.

In Inquisitive Semantics, the contrast between the primary and the secondary information is captured in the distinction between the proposed and the imposed content (AnderBois et al., 2010; AnderBois, 2010; Farkas and Bruce, 2010; Ciardelli et al., 2012).

Two types of informative updates: imposition and proposal

- The notion of a proposal dates back to Stalnaker's (1978) insight that the effect of an assertion on the context is the addition of the content of that assertion to the context, 'provided that there are no objections from the other participants in the conversation'.
- Farkas and Bruce (2010); AnderBois et al. (2010) further develop this idea by showing that proposals are both informative and negotiable updates of the common ground.
- Ordinary assertions can be confirmed, rejected, or discussed by the conversational participants prior to their addition to the common ground and thus, are proposals, rather than automatic updates of the common ground.

(1) A: Bella is a vampire.

B: Yes, she is./No, she couldn't be, she can walk in the sun./Why do you think so?

Two types of informative updates: imposition and proposal

- Impositions (AnderBois et al., 2010; AnderBois, 2010; Ciardelli et al., 2012) are informative updates as well, but contrary to proposals they are non-negotiable.
- Impositions are not intended to be discussed.

(1) A: Lupin, who is teaching the Defense Against the Dark Arts this year, is a werewolf.

B: Yes, he is./No, he isn't./Why do you think so?

- The contribution of the appositive is informative, but the speaker does not intend it to be negotiable.
- The continuations uttered by B confirm, reject, or further discuss the proposed proposition Lupin is a vampire and not the imposed proposition Lupin is teaching the Defense Against the Dark Arts this year.

Two types of informative updates for embeddings and parentheticals

- An embedding:

(1) [Who said that Sam is a vampire?] Dean said that Sam is a vampire.

$<\text{say(Dean, Sam is a vampire)}_{\text{PROPOSAL}}>$

(2) [Who is a vampire?] Dean said that Sam is a vampire.

$<\text{say(Dean, Sam is a vampire)}_{\text{IMPOSITION}}, \text{Sam is a vampire}_{\text{PROPOSAL}}>$

- A parenthetical:

(3) [Who is a vampire?] Sam, Dean said, is a vampire. / Sam is a vampire, Dean said.

$<\text{say(Dean, Sam is a vampire)}_{\text{IMPOSITION}}, \text{Sam is a vampire}_{\text{PROPOSAL}}>$

Embeddings and parentheticals: Follow-up questions and negation

- While a follow-up question can address the attitude predication part in regular embeddings, it cannot address the attitude predication part in a parenthetical:

(1) a. A: US papers reported that Sam is running for political office. B: Did they?

b. A: Sam, US papers reported, is running for political office. B: #Did they?

- In terms of the semantically embedded proposition we see regular embeddings and slifts aligned:

(2) a. A: US papers reported that Sam is running for political office. B: He is?

b. A: Sam, US papers reported, is running for political office. B: He is?

Embeddings and parentheticals: Follow-up questions and negation

- While a follow-up negation can address the attitude predication part in regular embeddings, it cannot address the attitude predication part in a parenthetical:

(1) a. A: US papers reported that Sam is running for political office. B: No, they didn't.

b. A: Sam, US papers reported, is running for political office. B: (#No / √Actually), they didn't.

- In terms of the semantically embedded proposition we see regular embeddings and slifts aligned:

(2) a. A: US papers reported that Sam is running for political office. B: No, he isn't.

b. A: Sam, US papers reported, is running for political office. B: No, he isn't.

Embeddings and parentheticals: Addressing the QUD

- As was first noticed in (Urmson, 1952) and was later developed in (Simons, 2007), a proposition can address the QUD both in case it is embedded under a regular embedding and in case it is embedded under a parenthetical:

  (1) a. Who is a vampire? Dean said Sam is a vampire.

  b. Who is a vampire? Sam, Dean said, is a vampire.

- When the QUD requires an answer to be the whole attitude predication, only regular embeddings, but not parentheticals prove to be felicitous:

  (2) a. Who said that Bella is a vampire? Dean said that Sam is a vampire.

  b. Who said that Bella is a vampire? #Sam, Dean said, is a vampire.

Embeddings and parentheticals: Focus and contrastive topic accents

- The attitude part can be accented in embeddings, but not in parentheticals:

(1) Who said Bella is a vampire?

a. JACOB$_{FOC}$ said Bella is a vampire.

b. #Bella, JACOB$_{FOC}$ said, is a vampire.

(2) Who said who is a vampire?

a. JACOB$_{FOC}$ said BELLA$_{FOC}$ is a vampire.

b. #BELLA$_{FOC}$, JACOB$_{FOC}$ said, is a vampire.

(3) Who said Bella is a vampire?

a. Well, JACOB$_{CT}$ said ALICE$_{FOC}$ is a vampire.

b. #Well, ALICE$_{FOC}$, JACOB$_{CT}$ said, is a vampire.

Embeddings and parentheticals: Focus and contrastive topic accents

- In terms of the semantically embedded proposition we see them aligned:

(1) Who is running for political office?

a. The papers reported that Sam_{FOC} is running for political office.

b. Sam_{FOC} is running for political office, the papers reported.

Update semantics: embeddings vs. parentheticals

Discourse updates:

imposition: an informative non-negotiable update of the common ground

proposal: an informative negotiable update of the common ground

(a) a regular embedding update for
Sam said that Dean has left town

Dean has left town – a proposal
Sam said that Dean has left town – an imposition

OR

Sam said that Dean has left town – a proposal

(b) a corresponding parenthetical update for
Dean has left town, Sam said

Dean has left town – a proposal
Sam said that Dean has left town – an imposition

Embeddings and parentheticals: update semantics

- The initial state of a discourse (before a linguistic expression of interest is uttered) is the common ground, a set of propositions already confirmed by the discourse participants, whose intersection is the context set (CS) modeled with a propositional variable p^{cs} that stores the current common set and all its non-empty subsets.
- Both proposals and impositions are informative: they contribute new information. This means that their updates would restrict the values assigned to the variable p^{cs}. But they would do so differently.
- Proposals are updates associated with ordinary assertions. The intuition behind them is that the speaker proposes to his interlocutors to consider the content of the assertion expecting them to doubt, support, reject or adopt it. In the latter case, the content of the assertion will enter the common ground.
- Impositions are informative updates as well, but they are non-negotiable. They eliminate worlds incompatible with their propositional content from the p^{cs} directly.

Embeddings: update semantics

Context Set: $\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$

[[Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_2\}$

[[Jacob said that Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_3\}$

Who said that B is a vampire?

J said that B is a vampire.

p^{cs}
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$
$\{w_1, w_3\}$
$\{w_2, w_3\}$
$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_2\}$
$\{w_3\}$

$\xrightarrow{\text{PROP}}$

p^{cs}	p
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_1, w_3\}$
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_3\}$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_1, w_3\}$	$\{w_1, w_3\}$
$\{w_1, w_3\}$	$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_1, w_3\}$	$\{w_3\}$
$\{w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_3\}$
$\{w_1\}$	$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_2\}$	$\emptyset$
$\{w_3\}$	$\{w_3\}$

$\xrightarrow{\text{PROP}}$

p^{cs}	p
$\{w_1, w_3\}$	$\{w_1, w_3\}$
$\{w_1\}$	$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_3\}$	$\{w_3\}$

Embeddings and parentheticals: update semantics

Context Set: $\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$

[[Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_2\}$

[[Jacob said that Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_3\}$

Who is a vampire?

J said that B is a vampire.

B is a vampire, J said.

p^{cs}
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$
$\{w_1, w_3\}$
$\{w_2, w_3\}$
$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_2\}$
$\{w_3\}$

$\xrightarrow{\textbf{PROP}}$

p^{cs}	p
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_1, w_2\}$
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_2\}$
$\{w_1, w_3\}$	$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_1, w_2\}$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_2\}$
$\{w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_2\}$
$\{w_1\}$	$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_2\}$	$\{w_2\}$
$\{w_3\}$	$\emptyset$

$\xrightarrow{\textbf{IMP}}$

p^{cs}	p
$\{w_1, w_3\}$	$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_1\}$	$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_3\}$	$\emptyset$

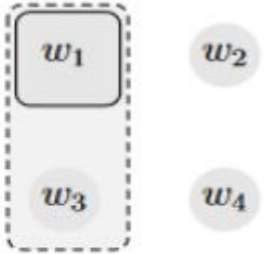
$\xrightarrow{\textbf{PROP}}$

p^{cs}	p
$\{w_1\}$	$\{w_1\}$

Embeddings and parentheticals: the discourse behavior facts revisited

Context Set: $\{w_1, w_2, w_3, w_4\}$
[[Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_2\}$
[[Edward is a vampire]] = $\{w_3, w_4\}$
[[Jacob said that Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_3\}$
[[Edward said that Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_2, w_4\}$

(a) *Jacob said that Bella is a vampire.*

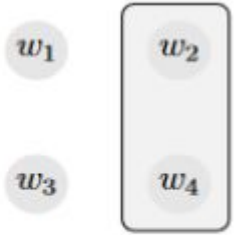


(b) *Bella is a vampire, Jacob said.*

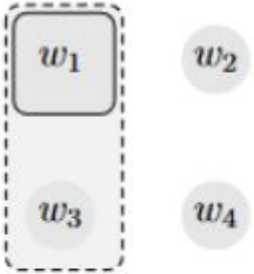
Embeddings and parentheticals: the discourse behavior facts revisited

Context Set: $\{w_1, w_2, w_3, w_4\}$
[[Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_2\}$
[[Edward is a vampire]] = $\{w_3, w_4\}$
[[Jacob said that Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_3\}$
[[Edward said that Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_2, w_4\}$

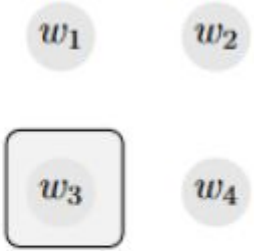
(a) *A: Jacob said that Bella is a vampire.*



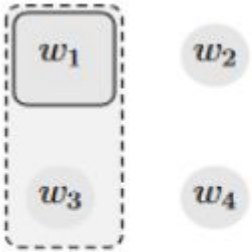
(b) *B: No, he didn't.*



(a) *A: Bella is a vampire, Jacob said.*



(b) *B: No, she isn't.*

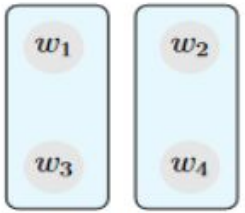


(a) *A: Bella is a vampire, Jacob said.*

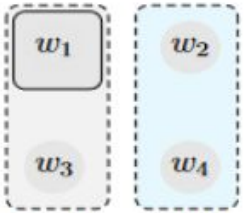
(b) *B: #No, he didn't.*

Embeddings and parentheticals: the discourse behavior facts revisited

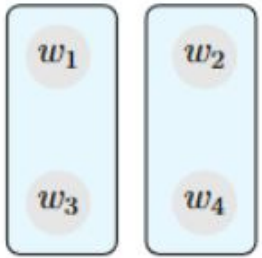
Context Set: $\{w_1, w_2, w_3, w_4\}$
[[Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_2\}$
[[Edward is a vampire]] = $\{w_3, w_4\}$
[[Jacob said that Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_3\}$
[[Edward said that Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_2, w_4\}$



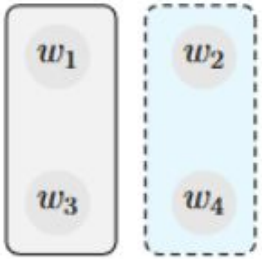
(a) *A: Who said that Bella is a vampire?*



(b) *B: #Bella, Jacob$_{FOC}$ said, is a vampire.*

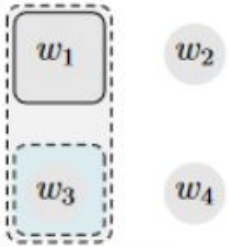


(a) *A: Who said that Bella is a vampire?*



(b) *B: Jacob$_{FOC}$ said that Bella is a vampire.*

(a) *A: Who is a vampire?*



(b) *B: Bella$_{FOC}$, Jacob said, is a vampire.*

Encoded discourse strategies: factivity in constructions with propositional verbs

The Puzzle

- A well-documented (Jackendoff 1972, Ross 1973, Hooper 1975, Koev 2021) empirical contrast in (1):

(1) a. *Sam {denied/is happy} that Dean has left town.* EMBEDDING

b. **Dean has left town, Sam {denied/is happy}.* PARENTHETICAL

- Hooper (1975): assertive predicates (*think*, *guess*, *explain*, *be afraid*, *hope, find out*, *know*, *realize*, *remember*) can occur in the parenthetical construction (1b), nonassertive predicates (*doubt*, *deny, regret*, *forget*, *be sorry*, *be interesting*) cannot.
- Assertive predicates 'imply that the speaker or subject of the sentence has an affirmative opinion regarding the truth value of the complement proposition' (Hooper, 1975, p. 95).
- Predicates that express a negative attitude toward the embedded proposition (*deny, doubt, pretend, wish*) and factive predicates that presuppose the truth of their complement (*be happy, regret, forget*) can appear in regular embeddings (1a) but not in parentheticals (1b).

The Proposal

- To occur in a parenthetical of the type (1b) an attitude predicate: a) must not be factive: it must not conventionally presuppose the truth of its propositional argument and assert the content of the attitude predication part; b) must not entail that the speaker does not believe the propositional argument to be true.

- Let's frame the discourse behavior of embeddings and parentheticals, as well as the discourse behavior of factive predicates, in terms of discourse updates: impositions (AnderBois et al. 2010) and proposals (Farkas and Bruce 2010).

- Let's show that the discourse strategy encoded in parentheticals (1b) is incompatible with the discourse strategy encoded in factive predicates and negative attitudes.

The Roadmap

- remind ourselves of the discourse behavior facts for parentheticals and embeddings
- frame the discourse behavior facts in terms of updates
- examine the discourse behavior facts for factive predicates
- show that the factive and the parenthetical strategies clash
- show that negative attitudes are infelicitous in parentheticals
- draw some conclusions

Discourse behavior: parentheticals and embeddings

In parentheticals, the embedded proposition (*Dean has left town*) can answer a QUD, can be negated in the following discourse, while the attitude predication (*Sam said that Dean has left town*) cannot, it is discourse inert:

(1) A: *Who has left town?*

B: *Dean has left town, Sam said.*

(2) A: *Who said that Dean has left town?*

B: #*Dean has left town, Sam said.*

(3) A: *Dean has left town, Sam said.*

B: *No (Dean has not left town/#Sam did not say that).*

Discourse behavior: parentheticals and embeddings

In embeddings, both the embedded proposition (*Dean has left town*) and the attitude predication (*Sam said that Dean has left town*) can answer a QUD, can be negated in the following discourse:

(1) A: *Who has left town?*

B: *Sam said that Dean has left town.*

(2) A: *Who said that Dean has left town?*

B: *Sam said that Dean has left town.*

(3) A: *Sam said that Dean has left town.*

B: *No (Dean has not left town/Sam did not say that).*

Update semantics: embeddings vs. parentheticals

Discourse updates:

imposition: an informative non-negotiable update of the common ground

proposal: an informative negotiable update of the common ground

(a) a regular embedding update for
Sam said that Dean has left town

Dean has left town – a proposal
Sam said that Dean has left town – an imposition

OR

Sam said that Dean has left town – a proposal

(b) a corresponding parenthetical update for
Dean has left town, Sam said

Dean has left town – a proposal
Sam said that Dean has left town – an imposition

Discourse behavior: factive predicates

Factive predicates (Kiparsky and Kiparsky, 1970) presuppose the truth of their embedded proposition (*Dean has left town*), the embedded proposition does not engage with the discourse, while the attitude predication (*Sam is happy that Dean has left town*) can answer a QUD, can be negated in the following discourse:

(1) A: *Who has left town?*

B: *#Sam is happy that Dean has left town.*

(2) A: *Who is happy that Dean has left town?*

B*: Sam is happy that Dean has left town.*

(3) A: *Sam is happy that Dean has left town.*

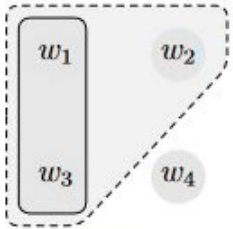
B: *No (Sam isn't happy/#Dean has not left town).*

Update semantics: factive embeddings vs. parentheticals

Context Set: $\{w_1, w_2, w_3, w_4\}$
[[Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$
[[Sam is happy that Bella is a vampire]] = $\{w_1, w_3\}$

(a) a factive regular embedding update for
Sam is happy that Bella is a vampire

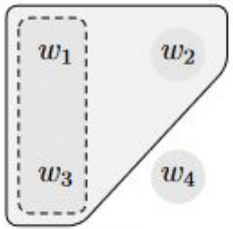
Bella is a vampire – an imposition
Sam is happy that Bella is a vampire – a proposal



(a)

(b) a corresponding parenthetical update for
**Bella is a vampire, Sam is happy*

Bella is a vampire – a proposal
Sam is happy that Bella is a vampire – an imposition



(b)

Update semantics: semi-factive predicates in parentheticals

Semi-factives (Karttunen 1971) can engage the discourse with both, the content of the attitude predication (1) and with the content of the semantically embedded proposition (2):

(1) A: *Who discovered that Dean has left town?*
B: *Sam discovered that he's left town.*

(2) A: *Who has left town?*
B: *Sam discovered that Dean has left town.*
B: *Dean has left town, Sam discovered.*

Since in the semi-factive strategy the attitude predication can be imposed and the embedded predication can be proposed, it is compatible with the parenthetical strategy:

(3) *He sounded,* ***he realized****, like the old magazine articles he'd started his career penciling up - genteel, bumptious, and with titles like "The Ideal Gimlet."* (COCA)

Pragmatic infelicity of negative attitudes in parentheticals

Discourse updates:

imposition: an informative non-negotiable update of the common ground

proposal: an informative negotiable update of the common ground

- a potential parenthetical update for
  **Dean has left town, Sam denied*

Dean has left town – a proposal
Sam denied that Dean has left town – an imposition

- Negative attitude predicates like *deny*, *doubt*, *pretend*, *wish* entail that the speaker does not believe the content of the semantically embedded proposition (*Dean has left town*) to be true.

- This pragmatically undermines the speaker's intention to propose the content of the semantically embedded proposition in the parenthetical construction.
- If the speaker chooses to use a construction with an imposed and a proposed part, he wants the proposed information to be added to the common ground and his default strategy is to provide the strongest reliable evidence via an imposition to make the associated proposal successful.

- we framed the discourse behavior facts in terms of updates, impositions and proposals
- and showed that the factive and the parenthetical strategies clash
- we also showed that negative attitude predicates are infelicitous in parentheticals

- Is the discourse status of the information determined solely by the conversational structure or is it conventionally specified for certain lexical items and constructions? (Simons et al., 2010)

- Parentheticals, embeddings, factive predicates, negative attitude predicates encode certain discourse strategies which determines how they interact with each other, the speakers' intentions and the context

Taxonomy of semantic content

Presupposition vs. Imposition

- Presuppositions form a diverse class of meanings
- Zeevat (1992) splits the presupposition triggers into resolution triggers, lexical triggers and bookkeeping triggers based upon how ‘anaphoric’ they are.
- The most anaphoric category of presupposition triggers, which he calls resolution triggers, are those which ‘collect entities from the environment in order to say new things about them’ (Zeevat 1992: 397). Definite descriptions, such as *the President of the United States* and *the Secretary-General of the United Nations*, are prime examples.
- Lexical triggers are expressions relating to actions and states that trigger presuppositions about their logical prerequisites, *know*, *stop*.
- The ‘bookkeeping’ triggers such as *too*, *another*, *also* and *again* allude to established entities such as people or events and relate them to the material that is currently being foregrounded.
- Lexical, but not resolution or bookkeeping triggers, are a potential source of impositions.

Conventional implicature vs. Imposition

- Conventional implicatures are the source of impositions
- The same empirical basis: evidentials, appositives, parentheticals
- Conventional implicatures are
  - non-cancellable
  - conventional
  - speaker-oriented
  - independent from at-isse meaning
  - projective
  - non-backgrounded
- It is easy to see that all these properties are associated with impositions as well.

Not-at-issue content vs. Imposition

- Simons et al. (2011) propose a distinction between at-issue meaning / content that addresses the QUD and does not project and the not-at-issue meaning / content that does not address the QUD and projects.

  (1) QUD: What most surprised you about the first graders?

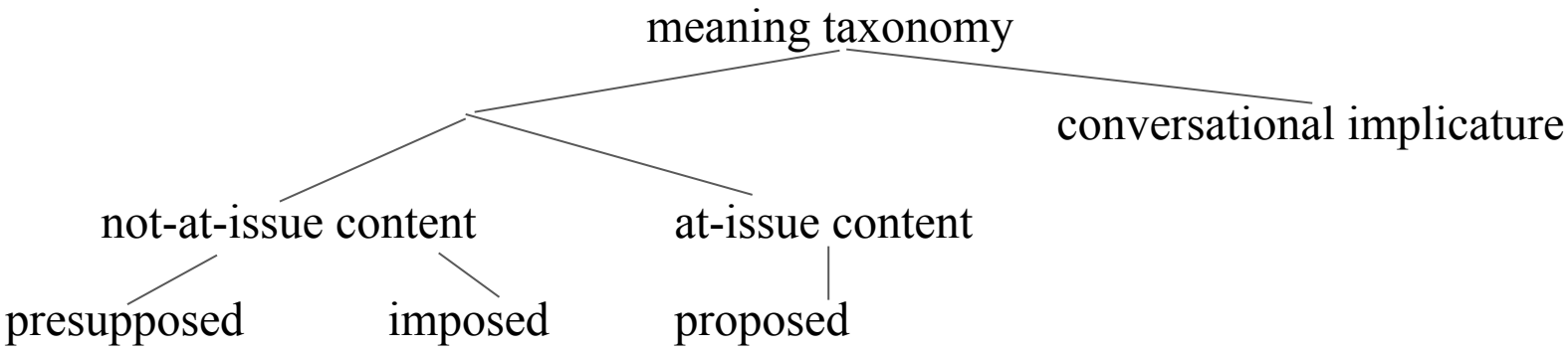
  They didn’t know that you can eat raw vegetables.

  a. You can eat raw vegetables. – not-at-issue, projects

  b. They knew that you can eat raw vegetables. – at-issue, does not project

- Imposed content does not address the QUD and projects, hence it is not-at-issue.

Taxonomy of semantic content



Presuppositions as preconditions vs. presuppositions as impositions

- Presuppositions are constraints or preconditions on the current information state/CS.
- They are required to be satisfied throughout the entire input information state/CS.
- That is, any assignment g in the input information state has to satisfy the presupposition.
- Presupposed meaning is taken for granted and anaphorically links the non-presupposed (at-issue and/or appositive) meaning with its context of interpretation. (AnderBois et al. 2013)

John^x, who nearly killed a^y woman with his$_x$ car, visited her$_y$ in the hospital.

a. **New proposal**: $[p] \wedge p \subseteq p^{cs} \wedge$
b. **Issue**: $[x] \wedge x = \text{JOHN} \wedge$
c. **Appositive**: $[y] \wedge \text{WOMAN}_{p^{cs}}(y) \wedge \text{NEARLY-KILL}_{p^{cs}}(x, y) \wedge$
d. **Issue**: $\text{VISIT}_p(x, y) \wedge$
e. **Proposal accepted**: $[p^{cs}] \wedge p^{cs} = p$

Presuppositions as preconditions vs. presuppositions as impositions

p^{cs}
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$
$\{w_1, w_3\}$
$\{w_2, w_3\}$
$\{w_1\}$
$\{w_2\}$
$\{w_3\}$

$\xrightarrow[\text{1:AT-ISSUE}]{p \subseteq p^{cs} \wedge x = \text{JOHN}}$

p^{cs}	p	x
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$	*john*
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_1, w_2\}$	*john*
$\{w_1, w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_1, w_3\}$	*john*
	...	
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_1, w_2\}$	*john*
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_1\}$	*john*
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_2\}$	*john*
$\{w_1, w_3\}$	$\{w_1, w_3\}$	*john*
$\{w_1, w_3\}$	$\{w_1\}$	*john*
$\{w_1, w_3\}$	$\{w_3\}$	*john*
$\{w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_2, w_3\}$	*john*
$\{w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_2\}$	*john*
$\{w_2, w_3\}$	$\{w_3\}$	*john*
$\{w_1\}$	$\{w_1\}$	*john*
$\{w_2\}$	$\{w_2\}$	*john*
$\{w_3\}$	$\{w_3\}$	*john*

$\xrightarrow[\text{2:APPOS}]{\text{who}_x \text{ nearly killed a}^y \text{ woman in } p^{cs}}$

p^{cs}	p	x	y
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_1, w_2\}$	*john*	$woman_1$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_1, w_2\}$	*john*	$woman_2$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_1\}$	*john*	$woman_1$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_1\}$	*john*	$woman_2$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_2\}$	*john*	$woman_1$
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_2\}$	*john*	$woman_2$
$\{w_1\}$	$\{w_1\}$	*john*	$woman_1$
$\{w_1\}$	$\{w_1\}$	*john*	$woman_2$
$\{w_2\}$	$\{w_2\}$	*john*	$woman_1$
$\{w_2\}$	$\{w_2\}$	*john*	$woman_2$

$\xrightarrow[\text{3:AT-ISSUE}]{x \text{ visited } y \text{ in } p}$

p^{cs}	p	x	y
$\{w_1, w_2\}$	$\{w_1\}$	*john*	$woman_1$
$\{w_1\}$	$\{w_1\}$	*john*	$woman_1$

$\xrightarrow[\text{4:AT-ISSUE}]{p^{cs} = p}$

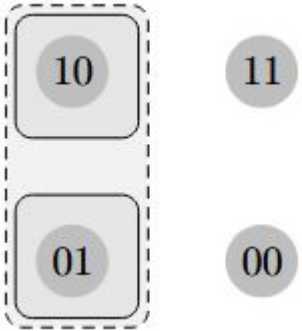
p^{cs}	p	x	y
$\{w_1\}$	$\{w_1\}$	*john*	$woman_1$

AnderBois et al. 2013

Presuppositions as preconditions vs. presuppositions as impositions

(1) Did Bella damage her car↑ or her bike↓ yesterday?

- Let 11 be a world where Jane damaged her car and her bike yesterday, 10 a world where she only damaged her car, 01 a world where she only damaged her bike, and 00 a world where she did not damage either.
- In uttering this sentence in s, a speaker imposes an update on s which eliminates the worlds 11 and 00, leaving only those worlds where Jane damaged either her car or her bike, but not both.
- Moreover, the speaker proposes two further updates, eliminating either world 10 or world 01, and thus establishing whether it was Jane's car or bike that she damaged.



Presuppositions as preconditions vs. presuppositions as impositions: the case of *stop*

- Sudo (2012) and Klinedinst (2012) argue that a major point of divergence between presupposition triggers is whether or not they also entail their presupposed content.

  (1) Victoria has stopped smoking.

- By common consent, the presupposition of (1) is that Victoria used to smoke.
- If we take the view that the presupposition and the asserted content mustn't overlap – if, for instance, we were committed to a theory on which the presupposition was necessarily background content and the assertion was necessarily foreground content – then we would have to conclude that the assertion was merely that Victoria doesn't smoke now.

Presuppositions as preconditions vs. presuppositions as impositions: the case of *stop*

(1) Victoria has stopped smoking.

- However, intuitively, what the speaker is trying to convey in uttering (1) is not merely that Victoria doesn't smoke now but that she recently transitioned from smoking to not smoking. (2) illustrates this: the speaker seems to be proposing that a change in Victoria's status as a smoker is a possible explanation of her observed mood. What they are saying is not accurately paraphrased as 'Perhaps Victoria is tense because she doesn't smoke'.

(2) Victoria seems tense; maybe she's stopped smoking.

- In the case of *stop*, then, it looks as though the presupposition is also entailed by the asserted content of the sentence. We can't really say that the speaker presupposes the previous state and only asserts the current state: rather, they assert a change of state, which entails both the previous state and the current state. But the previous state is also presupposed, which explains why it survives when the sentence is negated, as in (3).

(3) Victoria hasn't stopped smoking.

Highlighting

(1) Is the door open?

a. Yes ⇒ the door is open

b. No ⇒ the door is closed

(2) Is the door closed?

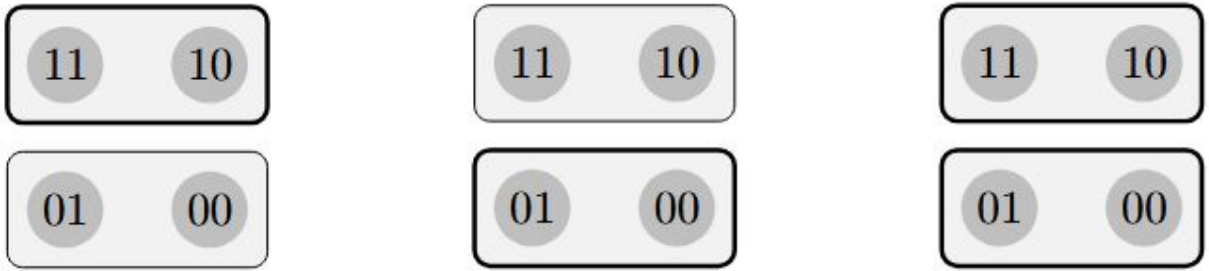
a. Yes ⇒ the door is closed

b. No ⇒ the door is open

(3) Is the door open or closed?

a. #Yes.

b. #No



Impositions going solo?

- We discussed imposition-proposal pairs like in *Bella is a vampire, Jacob said* and in *Lupin, a werewolf, is teaching the DADA this year*.

- The dynamic in the imposition-proposal pair is an interesting issue in itself, but there is another interesting question: are there utterances that are solo impositions?

- Can you think of some examples?

Impositions going solo?

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- The dynamic in the imposition-proposal pair is an interesting issue in itself, but there is another interesting question: are there utterances that are solo impositions?
- Can you think of some examples?

- My suggestions:

  (1) Rhetorical questions: How many times do I have to tell you? How should I know?

  (2) Exclamatives: What a great day!

  (3) Irony and Sarcasm: What a great lecture! Awful weather today!

  (4) Tautologies: Boys will be boys. Business is business. A promise is a promise.

Imposed and proposed conversational implicatures

- Conversational implicatures are excluded from the discussion of imposed/proposed content altogether since they are just too different: they depend on the Gricean maxims, are calculable, are not obligatory, can be cancelled, are reinforceable and suspendable.

(1) Poirot: Do you have children?

M. Battersby: I've never been married, Monsieur Poirot.

Poirot Agatha Christie Season 11 Episode 3 Third Girl

- Could we analyze the implicature that M. Battersby does not have children as an imposition or a proposal? And what is then M. Battersby's assertion in (1) – a proposal or an imposition?

Thank you!